

CHAPTER 20

THE PRISON WAYS

'A spy who peddles marijuana sounds heady.'

Once in three days, I was allowed visitors, and most of the times it was either my son Shankar or my sister's husband Arunachalam. I would listen to the tidbits of news he brought from home, mostly about my wife Meena who had not uttered a word since she fainted on the day I was taken away by the Vanchiyoor Police.

'Amma had some rice today, she was looking better,' Shankar would say.

I would remain motionless, mostly silent.

As days passed, I became more conversational. Shankar would reassure me that I would soon be out on bail, and be back home. The mention of bail only told me that I was still an accused. I wondered when I would be able to prove my innocence. But now I wanted to go home and be by Meena and our children. I wanted to give them the courage, and get some from them. I missed my family.

Sivanandan and the other employees at the prison made my life slightly easier, but I wondered during my long hours of solitude how convicts spend years away from their dear ones. Am I feeling so because I have done no wrong? Do repeat offenders and serial killers like Ripper feel no remorse and feel at home in prison?

Twice a week the prison staff would come for an inspection of our cells. It was more of a formality as we had nothing to keep in our cells, not even